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Chico Freeman

Chico Freeman was born in Chicago on July 17, 1949. His talents as a saxophonist, percussionist, keyboardist and producer have allowed him to find success in a wide variety of musical genres. Chico currently leads his own ensembles and can occasionally be heard performing alongside his father, saxophonist Von Freeman.

Chico was interviewed in New York City on January 13, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in New York City at the IAJE convention. I'm very pleased to have Chico Freeman with me today, who is a saxophonist and a multi-instrumentalist and in general doing what it takes to be in the music business. Is that a fair assumption?

CF: Yeah. Doing a few things that are involved in the music, yeah.

MR: So I have this feeling in reading about you that it wasn't just the saxophone or just jazz that you were interested in.

CF: That's true. I have a pretty varied background when it comes to music. I've been involved with different genres and types of music, because I like all genres and types.

MR: When you grew up, I mean you obviously had the influence of your father, but there was certainly lots of pop music and so forth going on at the same time. Which of it caught your attention first?

CF: Well naturally, like any kid, teenager, you grow up listening to the music that you grow up listening to, so I was no different. So at first it was R&B, rhythm & blues, all the singing groups, because I actually sang in a singing group. I had my own singing group. I sang in a few — did all the talent shows in high school. So I was listening to R&B, which would be Motown and the Drifters and things like that. Coming from Chicago, there was groups like the Impressions, Curtis Mayfield, Jerry Butler, you know the Chicago groups that were there. And Chicago was pretty much a hotbed of talented artists. I mean Earth, Wind & Fire comes from there. I went to school with them in fact. Well I didn't go to school with Maurice, he was older, but the Emotions, we were together in class, we were in the same class. And a lot of Maurice's brothers, Freddy and Verdine. Because Maurice had some brothers that were involved with Earth, Wind & Fire. So I went to school with all of them. And it's like I grew up listening to that. That's where I started. Of course, at the same time I was listening to my father rehearse simultaneously in the house. So I was listening to people like Pat Patrick and Clifford Jordan and they'd come by the house and

they'd be rehearsing with my dad and his bands. Don Baldwin, Andrew Hill, Vernel Fournier.

MR: Wow. Now these guys are pretty modern players too. I guess I had this impression, I have to readjust my thinking, that they were pretty up to date. In other words they were not just playing swing.

CF: No. Well you see my history goes even further back than that. My father, my family, the Freeman family, my father has two brothers. Bruz Freeman and George Freeman. Bruz is a drummer and George is a guitarist. They all played with Charlie Parker. But prior to that, at that time they were the premier band in Chicago. My father is a legend and so are my uncles. But my grandfather is also one, he was one of the first black policemen on the Chicago police force, and my grandmother, my father's mother and father, Louis Armstrong lived with them when he came up from New Orleans during that period he was in Chicago, where he played with Benny Goodman, you know that whole period when Louis lived in Chicago.

MR: And King Oliver and all those?

CF: Yes. He lived with, when he first came up he stayed with my grandparents. And so my grandfather was also a piano player. And so my dad grew up listening to Louis Armstrong play duets with my grandfather, and my dad and his two brothers of course. My father was actually the first one to become a musician, even though my uncle Bruz was older. He's the oldest of the three. But he also has another history because he was a Tuskegee Airman. And he also served with Percy Heath. Percy Heath is a Tuskegee Airman. So a lot of history. And then my grandmother was very involved in the church, and she sang in the choir. And she sang with Mahalia Jackson, because her church, which was called the Church of God and Christ, Bishop Ford, who they actually named an expressway in Chicago after him, used to have these things in Sunday church where, in the Gospel world it is a very famous church. Mahalia Jackson sang there, all of the great — God, Clara Ward, all of the great Gospel singers, and my grandmother sang in the choir and sang with these people and played guitar. And that's what influenced my Uncle George to be a guitarist. So then I grew up in that environment when I was coming up.

MR: That's quite a background.

CF: Yeah.

MR: Did your father feel that music was a good profession for his son?

CF: Hmm.

MR: Did you get that impression, or did he kind of just let you—

CF: I'll tell you, my mother, you asked me about my father but I'm going to tell you about my mother and say she would say no. Clearly. She didn't want me to do that. My father

really got — he always told me it was difficult, and it is. But he never really tried to influence me. I did it on my own.

MR: Your mother probably would have been happier with a more conventional way of—

CF: She would have. And I came very close to it because I received a four year scholarship for mathematics to Northwestern University. And I attended Northwestern, I graduated from Northwestern University. I went to get a master's degree at Governor's State but by that time I got my master's degree in music. But prior to that I was going to be some kind of mathematician or, actually I got involved in computer science. And I almost went that direction. Because I became a computer programmer. I programmed in like Fortran, ALGOL and COBOL back in the — that's the early languages of computers. And I thought about it, but then I switched over to music. She wasn't too happy about that. But she wasn't—

MR: Remind me to ask you about the computer thing a little later in our conversation if you would. I want to ask you about what I read, you actually came to the saxophone later.

CF: Yes I played trumpet first. And that sort of happened, I don't know, the luck of the draw you might say. My dad was in the Navy. He served in the Navy. Actually he and Clark Terry were in the same band, the Navy Hellcats, and they went to Hawaii during the, you know. And down in our basement my dad had all of his Navy gear, and he had this little storage room down there. And my brother and I were down there as kids do, going through everything we could find. I was looking for anything — I found his bell bottoms, his Navy hat, you know everything, duffel bags, all that stuff. And we ran across two instruments, an alto saxophone and a trumpet. And it just so happened — I don't know how it happened, I just got the trumpet, and my brother took the alto. And we were down there, we had found it, and my brother found a reed, he put it on there, and I had the trumpet and we were playing. My father was upstairs. He said he heard all this noise. He calls it bleedin' and bladdin', but he heard this noise and he came down and he found my brother and I had found his instruments. So I joined the school band. I had been taking piano lessons first though. I had been studying piano. I had a private, a teacher at the school I was going to gave lessons. So I had been taking piano lessons. So then I joined the band playing trumpet. My brother later joined the band, ended up playing saxophone. Then some years later he switched to guitar and I switched to saxophone. So that's sort of how — and then he taught himself piano.

MR: I have to tell you that's a very similar story that happened to the Adderleys, Cannonball and Nat. Yeah, we could talk about that. Almost a similar thing happened. So did you get to use the horn in a professional setting at all, or was that post college?

CF: Which now?

CF: Yes, I say sorta kinda. I went through grammar school and high school and I was a little bit of a maverick you might say, a bit of a nonconformist in a way. My father had always taught me to follow my own voice, myself. That is a very, very strong concept that I think has always pervaded throughout this music. You know, particularly in the history of it. That the individual, the individuality and the originality is very important I think to the character of jazz. And so my father had always encouraged me to do that. And when I was playing the trumpet, I kind of got — there was one trumpet player that just got in my ear, and I couldn't get him out. I mean I loved him there, it was a pleasant thing, but as I was playing that's the only sound — I couldn't really get next to the other trumpet players in terms of tone. And that trumpet player was Miles Davis. I just had an affinity for him. I had seen, my father played with Miles Davis and John Coltrane when I was like five years old. And I don't know, and then the first record that I ever heard that made me decide that I wanted to be a musician and play music — and play jazz music I should say — it was "Kind of Blue," so Miles Davis. And then the next trumpet player after him that I liked the tone-wise was Nat Adderley. So they had the type of tone, you know that dark, brooding kind of, because Nat played cornet really, so he had a darker sound. Now the other trumpet players, like Freddie Hubbard and Lee Morgan and Clifford Brown, they all had great sounds but they were very big and more brassy kind of sound. And I wasn't into the marching band type of trumpet sound. So my big influence was Miles Davis. And I was trying to get that kind of sound. And I ran into some problems when I went to college with the classical teachers there. Because their concept of sound was completely different. And it really sort of got to me when I had — I loved this teacher — I had this trumpet teacher and I liked him. He was a nice guy. And he was trying to teach me. And I guess because he was so nice I wasn't so belligerent, I was more trying to be persuasive and explain to him about what I was hearing and see if there was a way that he could help me achieve those goals in addition or alongside or something. And he really didn't have the information or the vision to do that. So I tried to help him do that. So I went and bought him a bunch of Miles Davis records. And he came back and oh he just told me Miles Davis played out of tune and this, that. He just completely dissed Miles Davis.

MR: Great credibility with you.

CF: So after that I thought this, I don't know if this is really for me. You know? I was beginning to doubt that. And then one day I was in class and I picked up an alto saxophone for studying. Because I was in music education at the time. And we had to study other instruments. And I picked up this alto and something magical happened to me. And I did extremely well in this classroom. And when school break came there was a

gave me permission to do that. And so for the complete school break, it was about two weeks I think, you know, spring break, I practiced about eight to ten hours every day. I didn't have a break. I just, I mean that's all I did every day. And I found I fell in love. That was it. I thought it was my voice all along. And I was able to apply everything I had learned from playing the piano and the trumpet. And the idea was just to get the technique of the saxophone down, and the embouchure and all that. But as far as the musical knowledge, what I had gained through — and that's what happened. So I came back and I finished my proficiency in trumpet and I added saxophone, and I then joined the band in saxophone. They didn't think I could do it, too. Because the school was very, it was a good school, and the people that came there were pretty high level players. And so when I came I had to audition to be in the band on saxophone. And I did and I passed the audition and everything. They couldn't believe it but I did it.

MR: Great story. I wonder what your father thought all of a sudden when he started hearing the saxophone coming out of your room eight to ten hours a day.

CF: Well it was kind of funny because I can tell you, he didn't hear it. But it was kind of interesting, he was conducting these jam sessions in Chicago. And I mean everybody that came through town came there afterwards, from Rahsaan Roland Kirk, Clifford Jordan, Sonny Rollins, you name it. They would work the places in Chicago and afterwards they'd go to wherever my Dad—And I used to go down there on the weekends and just listen and I got exposed to like all the players from out of the city, from New York and other places. And I also used to go there and play, when I kind of got some courage and confidence in my improvisational skills. But I was playing on this classical mouthpiece, you know, a Selmer C Star.

MR: Selmer C Star.

CF: You know it. Right. And I was in the saxophone quartet in school. But you know I got up there on the bandstand, and if I remember correctly, it was my father and maybe Clifford Jordan might have been there and a couple of other people. And all these big saxophones — and here Chicago is known for big sounds you know. And my sound sounded like I was tearing paper. And I became totally, almost it was disheartening. Because there was just no sound. I mean it was great sound for the classical thing but it was terrible for being there. So my father gave me my first mouthpiece that, you know—

MR: Could get you somewhere.

CF: Get me somewhere. And I started doing that. So I eventually, later on, as I went through school and eventually graduated from Northwestern University with a major in music, a minor in math and proficiencies in both saxophone and trumpet, and that was what I ultimately ended up achieving.

MR: Yeah. At that point it's like, now what am I going to do. I want to be a musician, I want to have a career in music. Did you have a particular goal in mind?

CF: I don't know, after I got through college I had met Fred Anderson and he had introduced me to Muhal Richard Abrams and Bunky Green and Rufus Reid. Because Rufus and Bunky happened to be going to school there working on their master's degree I think at that time. And I had been offered positions by some corporations for computer work, I think IBM was one that offered me a position, and there was another one, I can't think — if I can think of the company's name I'll tell you — they'd offered me a position. They were sending me American Express cards you know, the whole deal. And after I got out of school I thought, I didn't want to go either way. So I decided to go back home and hang out with my dad and so that's what I did. So I started just hanging out with him and going to work with him and my uncle and going to his jam sessions and doing that. And then I decided I wanted to go add to my education, so I decided to go for my master's. So I went to Governors State University to study for my master's degree. And while I was doing that I had met Muhal Richard Abrams and so I started playing in his band. And I started working in the AACM Big Band. And there I met people like The Art Ensemble of Chicago, Anthony Braxton and you know, the movement in that direction, and Henry Threadgill and Air. But at the same time I was working doing a lot of R&B gigs and blues gigs. I was working with J.B. Hutto and Memphis Slim and in Chicago I just sort of started falling into, between going to school and working and having these gigs. And I started working with, there was sort of a fusion band called Street Dance that I started working with with some guys.

MR: Define fusion for me at that time.

CF: This was playing in nines and sevens and it was sort of — this guy was a Polish guy, Stan Kosky, it's hard to remember his name. And in Chicago I started playing on the north side, those kind of places, those kinds of gigs. And I met a guy named Kenny Elliott, who is now with Lou Rawls, has been with Lou Rawls for I don't know, for a long time, but Kenny and I, and then I got involved with Earth Wind and Fire when Maurice White had left. He had been with Ramsey Lewis for like, the Ramsey Lewis Trio, and then he left and he started his own band and there was a Chicago guy named Oscar Brashear and Sherry Scott and some other people. And I played with them for a minute, and then I was working around like I said doing the blues gigs, R&B gigs, and some jazz gigs with my uncle and studying and jamming. And I was filled with music. It was like all day every day, either practicing or — so that was pretty good. And I was studying. I was studying composition with Muhal, as well as being a part of his band. And then I decided to go to school to Governor's State University. And when I went there, this was great because all

a university without walls. You were allowed to have a certain number of instructors that could teach you things that you wanted to learn but they did not have to be a part of the university structure. So I was able to really study serious in-depth composition with Muhal Richard Abrams, which was a great composer, and get college credit for it. So everything was kind of working. And then the band performed at the Notre Dame Intercollegiate Jazz Festival, which all the schools, North Texas State, Richmond, Virginia — I'm trying to think — Raymond Ricker teaches there, I'm trying to think.

MR: Eastman.

CF: Eastman, Eastman, yeah. All of these, across the country. And the director of the band was Rory Carter. And I was in this great band. We had a great band. Because we had some of the professional musicians who were working in Chicago in this band. The band was tough. And we won the award for best band. I won two awards for best saxophonist and best soloist. We won — another guy won best composer, and best vocalist I think. So we won five awards. We took nearly all of it. And it was great. And because of that there was this program that the governor of Illinois had sort of an exchange program with the governor of San Paolo, Brazil. So I went to Brazil as a result of that and stayed down there and they sent someone up here.

MR: I see.

CF: So that was all during my school, working on for my master's degree. Rory Carter eventually became the head of Berklee in Boston. He's not there now, I think he's back in Chicago now teaching at another place, but I just ran into him here.

MR: Was the association with Muhal Richard Abrams — he was pretty modern, I mean pretty progressive, that whole contingent of players is that right?

CF: Yes.

MR: And did you like that kind of freedom in your music?

CF: Yes I did. I mean it was a new thing for me. I mean I had been playing a lot of straight ahead and pretty mainstream I guess, along with a lot of the R&B stuff and things like that. When I met him he showed me new ways of doing things which was quite startling. Actually it sort of got to me because his way of teaching was — as modern as he was, as he is — his way of teaching was always to go back in history. From him I learned more about the history of jazz than anything else. He took me back to Willie "The Lion" Smith and James P. Johnson and Louis Armstrong. I used to have to transcribe their solos. I mean the things I had to do with him, you would think, a lot of people would think, because of Muhal's reputation in his music, that he being so modern, that this was not likely, but he is very versed on the history of the music in all aspects. Historically speaking as well as musically speaking. And so that's what I was studying with him and

history you're bound to repeat it, and if you want to do things different you've got to first know the rules to break them, and all of that. So that was his premise that he operated from. And so it was a great experience for me.

MR: When was the first time you got to record?

CF: That's kind of interesting. I kind of recorded three albums almost simultaneously. It was a little unusual. The ACAM, which is the Association for the Advancement of Creative Musicians, had garnered some attention from the Japanese in Chicago, and there were some Japanese record companies that were coming over and recording a lot of that, Muhal was doing records and Henry and everyone. And they had caught, I had caught their eye as well. And there was a guy, he came over, and I was in New York. Actually when I left Brazil I came to New York and I actually never went back to Chicago. So by this time I was in New York. And while I was in New York I also met a guy named Robert Cummins, who had a record company called India Navigation. And I had caught his eye. So I actually, I think, if I get this right, I think the first record that, the Japanese fella, his name was Mahasico Eu came and we had a little bit of a language problem. And he thought that I would like to go to Chicago and make this record. And I thought he wanted to go to Chicago, when both of us would have preferred to stay in New York. And needless to say we ended up in Chicago. So I made the record there. And I think that was the very first one I did actually in the studio and recorded. I came back to New York. Then the next one I did I think was the India Navigation record, I think. But that was not the first — the India Navigation I think was the first one released maybe. I'm not sure about this, because it's a little bit fuzzy. But the reason I said there were three because after that I had joined Elvin Jones' band. So I was on tour with Elvin Jones and Elvin did the surprise and when I got to California he said, "I've got a record date for you." And I was surprised. He had secured a recording for me, it was under my own name and he was on the record. And that was for the Great Contemporary, Lester Koenig. So I did that record. And I'm trying to remember which was actually the first one that was released, which most people would think of as my first record, in terms of — but they were all recorded just about in the same time. I mean, within a month or two apart. So to tell you the truth I don't really remember which is actually the first one or the second. But those three came pretty close together.

MR: Can you describe what you were doing at that time?

CF: I was playing with Elvin Jones, I was working in his band.

MR: But I mean musically, is it possible to put a description on the kind of music.

CF: Well I was fresh in New York so I was open to everything. I had joined Cecil McBee's band, I was playing also with Mickey Bass, you know, and I got the job with McBee's

had. She passed away not too long ago. And Henry Threadgill had that job and he needed to go back to Chicago for something and he asked me to fill in for him and I did, and it was a great success and so they extended us another week. So I was with her. While I was doing that I was you know, just getting around New York, getting around, learning people, hanging out and meeting people. I then sat in with Mickey Bass and got hired to play. He had a month of Sundays and so after the Jeanne Lee thing, and so I was working with him. So that kind of music was real straight ahead. It was Michael Carvin and it was very mainstream. Jeanne Lee was a little more experimental, a little bit more, but she was a vocalist. But still, it was a little more experimental. Then Cecil McBee came and I sat in with Cecil McBee and John Stubblefield, he got a call to go with Nat Adderley, and so Cecil called me and I was playing with his band. Now that was more with the vamps and the kind of — it was mainstream to McCoy Tynerish kind of, I don't know. Categories are very difficult for me. But I was playing that. So I'm doing these three kinds of music at the same time. And then the loft scene sort of came up with these more progressive, experimental music. So I was doing that also. So I was doing a lot of music. And I found myself having my feet in various camps.

MR: I guess so. And it probably hasn't changed all that much, has it?

CF: No because I like to — I believe in what Duke Ellington said, there's only two kinds of music, good and bad.

MR: What was it like playing with Elvin Jones?

CF: Great. I mean John Coltrane was one of my biggest influences, and to be able to have worked with everyone that was in that great band. And I did, everyone except for Jimmy Garrison, because he had passed on before I got there. But I'm working with McCoy Tyner today. I mean in fact I have a tour with him this summer, a summer tour. And I'm scheduled to go to Las Vegas with him next month. And I've gone to Japan with him and I've recorded with him. So I still work with McCoy on and off. And Elvin Jones, I was some years with him. Working with Elvin was great. I mean to have that power, that drummer that propelled Coltrane, and to understand what that meant. Not just to hear it but to feel it and be a part of it was for me a very great thing.

MR: Those of us who don't know him, when you watch him, you get the impression that this could be a mean person.

CF: Oh he's the sweetest guy you ever want to meet.

MR: Isn't that interesting. Because I think it's something about — in fact I just saw a photo today of him, and he was playing, and he's got this look on his face, you know, like wow.

CF: That's called intense concentration.

MR: I guess so. But I'm glad to hear that he's a nice person.

CF: No, he's a nice guy. Working with him was an education, it was a pleasure, it was a dream come true. It was a lot of things for me. It was one of the best times with my musical life.

MR: Yeah. I know you've got a long list of people here, some of them being saxophone players also, you've played beside Joe Henderson.

CF: Um hum. I did a great concert, I had a great concert with him. This band was an awesome band to be a part of. There was a drummer that I had worked with, but he was great, he and my Uncle George had worked together a lot. And he worked with Sonny Rollins for many, many, years, his name is Eddie Moore. And Eddie in the musical community is one of the very revered musicians. And Eddie, after he died there was a festival out in California that they do every year, and they named it after him, the Eddie Moore Festival. And I played this festival and this band was Andrew Hill, Bobby Hutcherson, Ron Carter, Roy Hanyes, Joe Henderson and myself. So I had a great time doing that one.

MR: I guess so. Here's a kind of a hard question I think, but are you a type of improviser that thinks of technical things while you're playing as far as here comes this chord, I know what scales and everything goes with it and I can choose — I mean is it possible to talk about what you think about when you're improvising?

CF: Well yeah. I try not to think actually. It sort of depends if the music is fresh to me and new, like if I'm playing something that I don't know that I have to look at, read, or something like that, then I'm forced to think to a point. But I've spent many years trying to learn things to forget them. And I feel that it's more important to feel. The thinking process for me is done when I'm practicing and when I'm learning a song. And you know I try to work on those kinds of things then. But when I get up on the bandstand, I am interested in playing music, making music. And I think that to think, I don't think we can think that fast to capture the music, you know, the spontaneity. If you think, by the time you think something, the music has already moved on. So I don't think. I try very hard not to think. I use my ears and I mean I can recognize a chord if I have to look at something and read it, I don't have to think about what scales, because I know it so I just try to do that. So I don't really think about that. I am a technical player in terms of, I understand the technical aspects of harmony, I understand harmony and theory and I have my own systems and harmonic devices that I use and things like that. But I usually apply that mental energy prior to playing. When I get there and play I try to clear my mind of all things and let the inspiration and the thing come to me so that I can react and act in a moment's notice.

MR: What's it like for you today? Being successful in the music business, has it changed in the last let's say ten years?

CF: Yes. Very much. I'm not sure it's changed for the better. It's changed. I have questions about it. The institutionalization of the music has been good on one end and I think it's not good on another end. I think that the industry has standards and the concepts that they project as to what is acceptable in the industry, and it has for the first time gotten musicians feeling that the idea is to look backwards instead of looking forward. And I think music has always looked forward, with respect to its history. But I mean the industry, the idea of being an individual and being original is less strong today than it was in the past I think.

MR: And you think that the record companies don't encourage the individuality.

CF: No I think the record companies encourage musicians who sound like other musicians, musicians who are going back ten, twenty, thirty years, and trying to play like the people who invented and created that music at that time and sort of regurgitated, you know, almost like a repertory concept. And as opposed to the industry encouraging and signing and promoting original thinking musicians and artists to try to take the music further. You know we've always looked forward. You think of the greats, let's talk about the greats, the major exponents of the music that we all have come to admire and hold up as the defining factors. Right? You look at people like Monk, Charlie Parker, Duke Ellington, Count Basie, Louis Armstrong, Billie Holiday. When you look at these people, they have one thing in common and that is they were all original. Louis Armstrong was doing nothing that anybody else was doing. In fact, Mal Waldron, I work with Mal Waldon and Mal Waldron told me once that a musician would come and hear a guy play and if he was doing something that the musician had been doing for himself he would probably stop doing that to try to do something different. The originality was a very important thing. You listen to the sound between a Coleman Hawkins and a Lester Young or Ben Webster and Lester Young, you can hear that Lester Young was completely about being his own man. You know that story about in the band, I think it was Fletcher Henderson's wife or somebody's wife—

MR: Hampton I think, wasn't it?

CF: Yeah, I don't want to—

MR: I know, we don't want to misquote.

CF: I don't want to misquote.

MR: They had to replace Coleman Hawkins.

CF: Yes, and they took Lester Young down in the basement and played all these records of Coleman Hawkins and asked him — and Lester replied, "If you want him then you hire him." So you know Thelonious Monk, his style, and you look at all the great — McCoy Tyner, Thelonious Monk, Bud Powell, you know as far as pianists go. Bill Evans. You

They have their own sounds. Andrew Hill. Saxophone players — from Chu Berry to Lester Young to Coleman Hawkins to Ben Webster, Ornette Coleman, Charlie Parker, Eric Dolphy.

MR: I'm wondering if, because of so much education going on with jazz now that we've dissected everything they do and there is so much for people to copy that that's how they end up.

CF: Well that's the institutionalization, that's what I meant by it's good on one hand — I mean it preserves what they've done in a way, which I think is good. But the methodology and the thinking process for acquiring the knowledge — and I think that this music really is a different kind of, you know I think it really requires a different type of education. The standards, the rules, the things to get the spirit and the essence of the music is different than what the institutions, the kinds of rules that apply to institutions. You know I think it's a danger of it becoming a dead music in a way, like classical music, if it continues. Classical music, if you think about it, the great composers, Beethoven, all the people do is continually reinterpret the same thing. What was exciting about it was to hear Beethoven play or to hear Bach. That — and there's nothing wrong, see I don't have a problem with the repertory concept. I think there's a place for everything. But don't eliminate the other part. And that's what I'm afraid we are in danger of. And the powers that be — we are not fostering and encouraging artists to be artists. We are saying you have to be commercial. You have to subscribe to this way of doing a thing, and then maybe you'll sell records, maybe we'll sign you, maybe this, maybe that. And I think we're not, we're sort of insulting the listening public as well, and considering them to be not as intelligent. We are assuming that they're not as intelligent, or that they can't choose their own — let them listen to and choose what they like. I mean when I first heard Charles Mingus on a record, he was doing something I had never heard music do before. I was deeply involved in R&B and this music, and I heard this thing, I forget the record that Charles did, but the name is — it stopped me, and it was completely out of what people listen to and consider the normal. And I had never heard it. And I thought wow. How did he just think of that, to do that. And I think a lot of people could have that experience, you know? That's the experience people got with Louis Armstrong. Wow. Nobody was — how did he think to do this? Something that you never heard before. But you can't find those things if you don't let people, give the green light to look and search and be experimental with it. And that's what I'm afraid is happening, that's what I see in terms of the music business. Many people think — well you can create music, you can try to identify a market and then create some music to fit the market. And a lot of people, this is the way a lot of people make music today, as opposed to make the music that is in your

MR: Right. You've got a lot of different projects going on right now. You are doing some Latin music I see?

CF: Yeah well I also do a lot of Latin music. I worked with, you know Machito?

MR: Uh huh.

CF: You know Charlie Parker was in that band, Dizzy Gillespie, Hubert Laws. So yeah, I was with Machito for I don't know four or five years. And so I've played a lot of Afro-Cuban music. I've been to Cuba and I've played with Irakere and Chucho Valdez and some of the great musicians down there. I got to hear and learn about Chano Pozo and — you know I'd never met him but a guy named Changuito, who was one of the legends in Cuba at the conguero, and as well here with Tito Puente, I played with Tito Puente and Eddie Palmieri. I did a concert at Carnegie Hall where they brought McCoy Tyner and Eddie Palmieri together and I played with that situation, it was great. So yeah I've done a lot of Latin music, I love it, Ray Barretto, and I enjoy it very much.

MR: And how about, I see you have a new thing with your father here?

CF: Well as I said we play together. We've been playing together for years. And this was his 75th birthday, which we celebrated here in New York at the Blue Note and we had Dianne Reeves as a guest with us. And we recorded there live and that's what this record is, a celebration of his 75th birthday. So he and I are together on there along with Dianne Reeves.

MR: What's it like trying to find — I guess we've probably already answered this question — but trying to find a record label these days?

CF: These days it's more difficult than before I think. It's unfortunate but I would say the reason, there has been some not so good things that have happened to the record industry. A couple of years ago I think the Alliance, which was a large distribution, independent distributor — the nature of the record business has changed so that, and the way, back when Columbia, it was Columbia before it was Sony and Warner Brothers, they had in-house public relations departments and how everything was kind of in-house. The distribution was their distribution, they had huge distribution. And later the age of the specialists came on and they started to farm things out to — you know the PR became, as opposed to them trying to house everything so that happened. Alliance Distribution was one of them. They had sort of bought up all these small distributions so they had this major network of distribution throughout the country. And they went bankrupt a couple of years ago, two or three years ago. And that sent a ripple effect through the distribution network and a lot of distribution labels — I mean small labels, independent labels, which were great, it was a great thing, and during the time when I was coming here. Like India Navigation. That was the Contemporary. These great labels that had really good music

the first labels Sonny Rollins recorded for. And Ornette Coleman recorded on that label you know. Those kinds of labels, it's now more difficult for them to exist. But those labels made it possible for artists to be artists and get names and do things, whereas the major labels, the big ones, you were much more restricted in what you could do, what they wanted you to do and what they would do for you. So because of that bankruptcy going with Alliance, a lot of the smaller labels couldn't survive. So a lot of them have disappeared, those labels, that were really good, I think they were very good for the music. So now this is the thing that we're dealing with. There's some independent labels coming up. A lot of musicians are doing their own labels these days.

MR: Right. There's an awful lot of product out there.

CF: There's a lot of product out there. And that's another thing. I mean you can do a record, you can.

MR: You can, but should you?

CF: That's again, you could but should you. And you know the stores are inundated with product that nobody knows who these people are so it's difficult for people to go in there and look in a bin and see hundreds and hundreds and hundreds of CDs in there and they don't know what to buy. There's not a lot of radio these days. So it's not an easy situation. It's just very difficult. Thing have to change. I mean things always change, it's just a matter of being able to make it through the change.

MR: Right.

CF: I hope that answers your question.

MR: What's coming up in the near future? McCoy you said?

CF: McCoy, yeah, next month. And then I have a tour, I'm taking my band to Europe in March-April, the end of March and April. I'm doing a tour in Canada and the U.S. with a guy named Franco Ambrosetti, an Italian trumpeter and myself and it's going to be Buster Williams will be drumming. That's in June. And then I go to tour, a big festival tour with McCoy Tyner in July. So those are some of the things as far as playing. I'm also involved in some projects, I'm waiting on a project — I write for film.

MR: Oh great.

CF: So there's a film that I know that I have when they get the thing together.

MR: When the wheels finally—

CF: So I'm waiting for that to happen, so I'll be involved in that this year, hopefully everything goes well.

MR: What's the best — I don't know if you can think of this quite offhand, but what's one of the best musical situations that you've been involved in so far?

CF: One of the best? Oh there are a few. Well the one with McCoy is great. For me it's great.

This is great. This is one of the best right now. Outside of what I do myself, I think this is probably my favorite thing right now. And I love playing with my father when we do that. I also have worked with the band called Roots, which is like a saxophone quartet with a rhythm section. Actually the original band was great, it originally was Don Pullen on piano, we had Buster Williams on bass and we had Idris Muhammad in the rhythm section. Now it's Ed Thigpen, which he's absolutely wonderful drummer, and Buster and George Kape, or I'm sorry, Kirk Lightsey. And then there's Benny Golson, Arthur Blythe, Nathan Davis and myself. And so that band, when we do some things is — because being with Benny Golson and playing those Benny Golson arrangements and things, so it's really great, so I like doing that.

MR: How about the worst musical situation?

CF: Oh man, the worst? I honestly can't tell you because I think I put it out of my mind.

MR: But that's paying dues, right?

CF: Yeah. Well I think everything is a learning situation. And I believe that I've learned that the idea is to try to take a bad situation and make it as good as possible, as long as you're there. And if you can't do that then you should leave. So that's pretty much how I operate. And if I feel I have to leave and I don't want to do that then I try to keep that out of my realm. Because I believe in accentuating the positive and eliminating the negative. So that's generally — so I honestly don't remember what maybe was the worst situation.

MR: Well it's a good thing for students to think about, you know, like what you've done from playing with Blues bands on the south side, to doing Afro-Cuban music and absorbing all that, to get your own voice.

CF: Well the world is much smaller than it used to be. And that's a good thing. I've had opportunity to play with musicians from every culture, from Japanese, shakuhachi flute players, to Indian tabla players, I've worked with Haitian musicians, I've worked with African musicians, and when I say Africa, Africa as a continent not a country, so I've worked with musicians from Senegal, from Ivory Coast and they're different, from Mali, and Chinese music. It's really been, for me that's been a great thing. Cuban musicians, Puerto Rican musicians, musicians from — Panamanian.

MR: Did we have something we wanted to add over there? Because we can slide this in there.

CF: What is this? I can't read this.

[off camera comments]

MR: That was going to bring me back to my question, thank you. Right. Okay. I know you had this computer experience and knowledge all this time. Has it come back to resurface in your life and help you out?

CF: Yeah, it's been there for a while. It's funny, since I started, I got a scholarship for

programming. Some time back I programmed software for businesses. I wrote programs for a book store or a cosmetics company or a public relations firm to name two or three. And I enjoyed it, because I was good at it. But as the technology advanced and the languages advanced I started teaching myself other languages of course, in order to do this. But I realized that the languages started moving pretty fast and if I was going to continue with this I need to go back to school and get back deep into it, and that was taking a lot of time away from music so I decided not to do that. And I became a user, but a very savvy user. And I decided to use it in music. And as a result I've been involved in the recording aspects, the new digital recordings. Also I'm a producer and I have produced records both in the audiophile world, I don't know if you know what that is, and then the multi-tracking, the normal way of recording. So I'm versed in the technology and the way that audiophiles perceive and do things, as well as the digital world of Pro Tools, and I work Rocket Network which is, I'm now involved in an Internet recording situation. So I'm involved with him. I work with E-magic, that company which is software for audio and midi music production, and I work with some music instrument makers like Korg synthesizer makers, Korg and people like that. So I'm involved in that kind of work, I produce, I'm an engineer, I can engineer, and I know all the technical stuff. I'm involved in all of that. So as a producer, because I enjoy being in the studio and producing other artists as well as myself, but other artists, and so you need to have that kind of knowledge.

MR: Well it doesn't sound like you're being left behind in the world of technology in all aspects.

CF: No. I like to look forward. I think looking forward is a good thing. You try not to lose certain values that have, in the past have shown to be real truthful things that last. You know, things that are real. Because those are important values. But you need to learn how to take those things with an eye to the future, and keep innovating and continuing to add to it. That's what I try to do.

MR: Excellent. Well it's been a fascinating conversation and I wish you all the best in upcoming events.

CF: Thank you.

MR: It sounds like when you look at your week it's like different every day, right?

CF: Yeah, a lot of things, yeah a lot of things. But I practice every day so that's important. It has to be things that have to stay constant.

MR: I hope your tours go great—

CF: Thank you.

MR: —and everything else.

CF: Oh yeah, I'm an educator. That's one of the reasons I'm here. I teach at the New School.

MR: Right. That's pretty prominent.

CF: And I may end up teaching at a few other, at another institution soon. I haven't heard back so I'm not going to mention the institution.

MR: Okay. They'll probably call you about the same time the movie people do.

CF: Don't you just hate that, just waiting?

MR: Right. Well thanks so much for your time today. And I hope the rest of your events go well. It's been a pleasure.

CF: Yeah, same here. Okay.